ARCTIC CONVOY PQ-17



WORLD WAR II

ARCTIC CONVOY PQ-17

Date	July 2-10, 1942
Location	North of Norway
Result	German victory

COMBATANTS

ALLIES	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

John Dowding **Jack Broome**	**Various commanders**

FORCES

Ships: 2 battleships, 1 carrier, 6 cruisers, 30 escorts, 35 merchant ships	**Ships:** unknown

LOSSES

Ships: 22 merchant ships	**Ships:** none

Following the entry of the Soviet Union into the war in summer 1941, Britain and the United States began supplying Soviet forces with military equipment to fight the Germans. Some of these supplies were carried by convoys to the northern Russian ports of Arkhangelsk and Murmansk. Even without enemy action, Arctic convoys were a grueling struggle against freezing cold, gales, fog, and ice. The convoys were exposed to attack by land-based Luftwaffe aircraft in occupied Norway as well as from U-boats, and they were constantly threatened by the presence of German warships in the Norwegian fjords.

PQ-17 SETS SAIL

In June 1942 the largest Arctic convoy yet to sail, consisting of 35 merchant ships, assembled at Iceland. It was given three levels of naval defense: a close escort force of destroyers, corvettes, minesweepers, armed trawlers, and anti-aircraft auxiliaries. In support was a covering squadron of heavy cruisers and destroyers. Yet further off lurked a powerful force centered around the carrier *Victorious* and two battleships, *Duke of York* and *Washington*, hoping that the German big-gun ships *Tirpitz*, *Admiral Hipper*, and *Admiral Scheer* might come out. The Germans had in fact decided to launch a major operation against the convoy, which therefore became the unfortunate focus of a trial of strength between the two sides. Leaving Iceland on June 27, the convoy started to run into air attacks from July 2. The swarms of Luftwaffe aircraft met fierce resistance from the ships of the close escort and from guns on the merchant ships. Although two American merchantmen were lost on July 4, the situation seemed broadly under control. At this point, however, the British Admiralty made an



U-boat gunnery traverse table
German U-boats often surfaced to attack unescorted merchant ships with their guns, saving torpedoes for better defended targets.

Arctic hunter
A German U-boat cruises on the surface of the ocean. Arctic convoys were at constant risk from both U-boats and Luftwaffe aircraft.

